

BACKUPS THAT ALMOST DON'T COST YOU A THING

Graphic: Atul Deshmukh

Backup solutions need not burn a hole in your pocket. Presenting a guide that gives you the right options

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The most important component of your business may be your employees, but they're only as valuable as their data. This sounds clichéd, but think about it: Imagine losing all your company's data in a freak accident, or a virus attack. Imagine the hundreds or thousands of man hours lost. And then, even more hours will be wasted trying to recover or replicate records, presentations, internal documents, etc. Sounds scary? It is!

We rely a little too much on computers, or more precisely on storage components. And components will fail, sometime or the other. Backup is the name of the game, and you're playing against loaded dice, if you aren't already protected against a data disaster.

The SoHo segment is especially vulnerable to Internet threats and disk failures. Backups just aren't considered a necessity

here. Contrary to popular belief, getting a backup solution is not expensive, and doesn't require dedicated trained professionals.

Hard disk drives

Most SoHo setups have a LAN, so the simplest and cheapest solution is to have hard drive backups. A large capacity hard drive can be plugged into one computer—preferably the highest configuration PC in the office—to run as a server. We're looking at five to 10 people using this disk as a backup device, so it would be better if the LAN is switch-based, and not hub-based. Over a switch-based LAN, which runs at 100 Mbps, backing up data as large as 100 MB wouldn't take more than 15 seconds.

A Serial-ATA (SATA) hard drive is preferred. SATA is a standard feature on motherboards today, and offers peak transfer speeds of about 150 MBps. You also get 250 GB drives with an unbeatable price-per-MB ratio. Maxtor and Western Digital offer 250 GB drives at a price-per-MB ratio of as low as six paise and eight paise, respectively. So, you're only paying 6 paise for every MB of data you're backing up—unbeatable. All that needs to be done is to plug in the drive to a decent system, create separate folders for each user, and install backup software on each client machine.

The backup software installed should be scheduled to backup data at particular time interval. Ideally, this should be at least

thrice during working hours. This will ensure minimal data loss, if any occurs. Since this is a simple setup, with no policy defined, users will have to follow some guidelines—backing up only important office related files, not music and movies. Also, users shouldn't save files directly from the Internet, as these could be infected.

External hard drive

External hard drives are another option that can prove useful for SoHos, especially in offices where machines aren't connected over a LAN. External hard drives are available as both USB and FireWire drives, of which the USB interface is more popular. The USB 2.0 interface is hot right now, because of the faster data transfer speeds—480 Kbps.

The advantage of external drives is that they can be carried to individual machines and hot plugged. Another advantage is that USB-based drives don't need drivers with Windows XP. Even with older OSes such as Windows 98, the drivers need to be installed only once, on each machine.

External hard drives are more expensive than internal drives,



Maxtor 250GB external hard drive

but are available in large capacities, and come bundled with backup and restore software—which if bought separately costs much more. Some external drives also have a hotkey for instant backup.

The price-per-MB of external drives is about 20 paise to 33 paise, depending on the size and interface. They are handy, but involve a lot of manual effort to take backups.

Optical storage

CDs and DVDs are the most common choice for backups. CDs are probably the cheapest solution. DVDs store a lot more, but the media and writer are still expensive. They are only viable for designers and video profes-